

Affordable Touch

Samsung Korea has just announced the new Preston mobile phone, otherwise known as the Samsung S5600. This full touch mobile phone boasts of compact design and intuitive interface at a very affordable price.

Nokia Xpress Music 5800

This phone is Nokia's first try at a touch interface along the lines of the iPhone. It has a very compact, slightly elongated footprint. It's quite a light phone for its screen size of 3.2-inches. The 5800 is a well designed phone with good build quality and finish. Although the body and battery cover are plastic, nothing feels cheap or flimsy. The menu and call accept/reject buttons, although small, are raised and are easy to use. The onscreen keyboard is a number based keypad and will be a snap for Symbian users although it's not as fast to respond to a key strike as a hardware keypad; which takes getting used to. The Xpress Music button on the top right of the phone is touch-activated and simple to use. As mentioned, the resistive touch display is Nokia's first and although this doesn't work as well as the iPhone, it is an admirable effort nonetheless.

Basically the phone is plagued with a slow processor that while fast enough for mundane tasks lags when the screen is used. This becomes noticeable most of all while scrolling through certain menus where the phone's interface lags. At times, the menu also becomes a tad unresponsive. The screen is pretty clear and crisp and thanks to its large size, is very usable and fun to watch videos on. Music quality is good, but the loudspeaker should have been, well, louder. The 3.5-mm jack is well positioned at the top of the phone.

Signal quality in zone 1 was excellent although the phone didn't perform proportionately well in zone 2 and the performance dropped quite a bit. Handsfree clarity is good and the phone's loudspeaker is quite loud on call. The camera is good, and performs as well as the other aspects of the device. It's a feature-rich, touch-based phone that is novel enough to warrant recommendation — a good performer with a load of features that may never be used; priced at Rs. 21,839 the Xpress Music 5800 is good value, especially since its price is a good Rs. 3,500 lower on the street.



Nokia Xpress Music 5800

Samsung S8300 UltraTOUCH

This is a sleek phone finished in a nice contrast of black and metallic red. The rim of red around the glossy black bezel of the facia adds a really chic look; especially since the region around the screen's bezel has brushed metal tones. The phone is slim and long, but not very wide and the slider is ultra-slick; something we've come to expect from Samsung's sliders which are regarded as the best in the business. The volume button on the side is a two-way affair and works well thanks to its noticeable extrusion from the body. The camera button should have been a little softer — feedback is hard and the camera is therefore not as usable. The call accept/reject buttons are large and well laid out with great feedback. The tiny joypad button feels clicky but works well enough. The screen itself is good, clear and crisp with great colours — the menu icons look a little overdone though, and we prefer the clean icons that Nokia and Sony Ericsson use; however minor a point this may seem it's worth nitpicking over. There is a button to lock the screen on the side and this is the first time we've seen someone use something other than a slider-style button to activate/deactivate a touch screen. We found it took time to get used to and accidental pressing of this button is possible (this never happens with a slider mechanism) making for an annoyance if the device is in your pocket. Slide open to reveal the number keypad and you will discover flat keys that, despite no spacing, are well laid out in curving rows and offer good, positive (if slightly clicky) feedback. The keys are large and this makes the phone suitable for those with thick fingers. The camera is good in the sense of it offering a large megapixel rating but the contrast and sharpness is not as good as the Samsung Pixon; that being

said it does offer image stabilisation which is a plus over other

Nokia's entry-level splash

Nokia, the world's top handset maker, recently unveiled the 2720 Fold and 7020 entry-level phones, including the 2730 Classic -- the cheapest 3G phone to date.

camera phones and although this feature is digital and not optical, it works fairly well, unless you are zooming in. The video player is feature-rich and plays a variety of formats. We wish Samsung had provided in-built memory in the order of 16 GB — this would have made the unit a good video-based PMP-phone, since it has a good screen as well.

For someone looking at a phone with a great camera and screen; the latter mainly to play videos this phone is all you need, look no further. Everyone else can just take a look elsewhere as this phone doesn't come cheap at Rs. 27,500.



Samsung S8300 UltraTOUCH

Samsung M8800 Pixon

The Pixon is a neat looking phone. It's completely black, with a solid build quality and a nice metal battery cover. The finish is glossy but not overly so and the entire metal body is powder-coated. The screen is large and dominates things — a pity it has only 256K colours. The lack of bit depth shows when watching videos and such as it trails behind the Samsung S8300 by a good margin. The sidebar menu, similar to Windows Vista, is neat and offers all the menu options. A classic grid view is also available and the menu icons are good and very legible. Everything is well laid out, intuitive, and easily accessible. The call buttons are neatly placed and evenly spaced. There is no joypad but a single button provided in between the call buttons will take you to the start screen — similar to the home button on the Apple iPhone. The fonts are nice to read but the lack of a 16-million colour screen is visible with the colours of the menu icons. The camera looks the part of a high-end cellphone camera and its lens cover automatically snaps open when the camera menu is activated. The camera itself does a fairly good job except in dim lighting. Photos shot on the camera look quite crisp with good colours, and videos are better than average. With good

Mobile Phone Test

music playback abilities and support for a range of audio and video formats it's a pity that Samsung chose to provide a proprietary headphone socket instead of the de facto 3.5-mm standard which we feel should be mandatory. Call quality isn't as good as we'd like and the Pixon doesn't have the best of antennas. Although the handsfree unit provides decent quality we'd have liked the flexibility of using headphones of our choice. It's clearly a multimedia phone with strong PMP abilities and at Rs. 25,899 is the best camera phone of the bunch; although the margin of lead is very small.

LG Arena KM900

A beautiful phone finished in brushed aluminium, and polished white aluminium, with a narrow strip of chrome running right around the outer rim of the facia. The body feels solid due to all that aluminium. The rear cover is also metal and while it's difficult to get off owing to the silly retention used, once removed we observed that the interior is neat with the ability to remove the SIM card and microSD memory without having to remove the battery. The display is large and very crisp and the menu icons are undoubtedly the best we've seen, much better than the ones by Nokia and even Apple. The front panel call and menu buttons are touch activated and work pretty well. The phone's interface is snappy, although it



Samsung M8800 Pixon